

The Colonel in His Labyrinth

The BCCI pulls up the selection panel chief and brings its flawed selection structure into focus

■ By Sharda Ugra

With profuse apologies to Gabriel Garcia Marquez, this can only be called the *Colonel in His Labyrinth*. Dilip Vengsarkar, chairman of Indian selectors, former Test captain, may dislike the nickname 'Colonel' but the labyrinth is his own creation. When he took over the selection committee 13 months ago, among other tasks, Vengsarkar had the opportunity to shepherd a transition of generations in the Indian team with the objectivity of a neutral and the empathy of a fellow pro.

Instead, in spite of six successful months for the Indians, Vengsarkar has stumbled. A few prickly personal equations, with former captain Rahul Dravid and BCCI Secretary Niranjan Shah and a few false steps have cost him.

The BCCI's recent diktats against the "selectors" were targeted at one man alone, the only one of the five selectors who aired his views in newspaper columns.

Vengsarkar has written columns for the Marathi newspaper *Sakal* for more than five years, but it is his English columns that have upped the ante. Gameplan, the syndication agency that circulates the Vengsarkar column, denied that he was on their roster of regular columnists, saying his columns ran only sporadically.

Contrary views have also been expressed. That in the absence of a pay cheque from the BCCI, selectors are free agents to do as they please. That Vengsarkar was unaware of the rules. That if Vengsarkar cannot write, nor should Ravi Shastri or Sunil Gavaskar, who also hold other posts in the Board.

None of these arguments has a leg to stand on. Ignorance of BCCI's rules is no defence. Vengsarkar's predecessor

Kiran More is acerbic: "The chairman of the selection committee should know BCCI's rules and regulations." According to More, who had an eventful tenure as chairman, every new selector receives a list of the BCCI's dos and don'ts.

Shastri and Gavaskar's appointments with BCCI are not full-time, year-round, high-profile like Vengsarkar's. And salaries have nothing to do with it.

Irani Trophy, followed this year by columns during the T20 World Cup and the recent Challenger Series. He has kept leaving himself open to having his knuckles rapped very publicly by BCCI. The message from BCCI President Sharad Pawar, who met Vengsarkar in November, was that writing columns was "not proper".

Quite, but why did it take 12 months

to tell Vengsarkar that? In acting so late, the BCCI let itself down too. It also left itself open to the accusation that it had reacted to provocation (by the media or vested interests) rather than on principle.

Indian cricket is now an industry and every match is but a profit-and-loss venture for the ever-expanding circle of those with commercial interests in the sport: television rights holders, big and small corporate sponsors, in-stadia rights holders, agents who buy and sell space of all kinds on a cricket ground, player agents, syndication agencies and the amorphous crew of wheelers and dealers.

The richer the game grows, the more critical it is for those directly involved with it—ground officials, se-

lectors, players—to be and, as important, to be seen as independent of commercial interests. With Vengsarkar's double role of selection committee chief and syndicated columnist, the exact reverse happened.

There are too many stories of former selectors leaning on players to sign up with their agent of choice: four members of the current Indian team have stories to tell. The BCCI's selection structure has been due for an overhaul since, oh about 1945. Maybe this episode will provide the spur. ■



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Propriety and conflict of interest issues do. No matter how unimpeachable a selector may be, writing columns does not reinforce the message that he can keep a confidence. No matter what the acoustics, the optics remain all wrong. Vengsarkar's recent actions have made his selectorial colleagues uneasy as the image of the panel has taken a beating for no fault of theirs.

In October 2006, about a fortnight after he had been appointed national selector, Vengsarkar's first English-language column appeared during the